

ANI

There was not even a moment's hesitation when Sabita (*name changed*), 17, was asked to show her Aadhaar and admit cards at the St Francis Xavier's School in Varanasi. It was September 12, 2021, and the CBSE-affiliated school, located in the Sona Talab area of the temple city in Uttar Pradesh, was serving as one of the centres for the year's NEET or National Eligibility cum Entrance Test for medical admissions. Sabita was given entry, and allowed to write the exam.

It was only when she came out three hours later that police inspector Anjani Kumar Pandey stepped up to check on a few more details. Like where she took her Class 12 examination from. What was the name of her school principal? What could she tell them about Tripura, where she was from? How many rooms did her house have?

Three minutes into the interrogation and Sabita's façade crumbled. She was actually Julie Kumari from Patna, a second-year dental surgery student at the Banaras Hindu University. She had agreed to appear for the exam in place of Sabita for Rs 5 lakh, of which her mother Babita had already collected Rs 50,000 in advance. Both Julie and her mother, who was also at the exam centre while her daughter was writing the exam, were arrested. A fake Aadhaar card, NEET admit card, photographs, two mobile phones and other documents were also recovered from the duo. A day later, the police nabbed one Osama Shahid, 31, a final-year medical student at the King George's Medical University (KGMU) in Lucknow.

Shahid is now in judicial custody and is believed to be one of the masterminds of the 'fake candidate' racket along with Patna resident Neelesh alias PK, 40, who is also in judicial custody, and Om Prakash Singh, 52, a B.Pharma degree holder once associated with KGMU, who was arrested on January 13 from Lucknow. In December, the cops had arrested Sabita and her father Gopal Biswas in Tripura, where he runs a drug store. Being a minor, Sabita is currently in a juvenile facility. Biswas confessed to having paid PK an advance of Rs 5 lakh, in return for helping Sabita 'crack' the NEET. The total deal was for Rs 50 lakh, and Biswas was to pay the remaining Rs 45 lakh after Sabita secured admission. Once PK received the advance, his accomplice Shahid arranged for Julie to appear for the exam as Sabita.

Examination by Proxy

Proxy candidates for prestigious examinations such as the NEET or JEE Mains for the IITs, or for recruitment exams for school teachers, constables, banks or railways, are as old as examinations themselves. With rampant unemployment and a premium on government jobs, clearing any of these exams is seen as a passport to lifelong financial security. And it is this desperation, especially in smaller towns and villages, that the swindlers feed into, helping them earn easy money.

The modus operandi is fairly simple. Talking of a demand side and a supply side, Varanasi police commissioner A. Satish Ganesh, elaborates: "The racket works at both levels. One group ascertains the demand by tapping coaching centres to procure data on candidates from well-off families who have failed to clear NEET in previous attempts. The second group works with medicos like Shahid to identify bright students in the first or second year of medical college from financially weak families."

Once a parent agrees to pay for a proxy to take the exam in place of their ward, he or she is asked to pay an advance. Post-dated cheques and the candidate's original Class 10 and 12 marksheets have to be deposited as security, which are returned after receiving the total payment of Rs 50 lakh.

CHEAT SHEET

Cheating in India is as old as examinations themselves—endemic, organised and elaborate

- **Impersonators can be found writing prestigious exams** such as the NEET and JEE Mains, as well as recruitment exams for school teachers, constables, bank officers and railways personnel
- **In 2021, FIRS were filed** against NEET impersonators in Maharashtra, Uttar Pradesh and Rajasthan
- **Though there is no combined figure for the number of arrests** made for impersonation in examinations, according to the NCRB 2020 Crime in India report, 613 people were arrested for cheating by impersonation. 115 of these were up to the age of 30
- **1,283 cases are pending for investigation**, as per the NCRB report
- **The railways have filed over 200 FIRs** in the past five years against cheaters and impersonators in exams conducted by them in various states
- **Over 1,000 people, including 300 proxies, have been arrested in Bihar** in the past seven years
- **460 people were arrested in Bihar** in 2020 for impersonation during the statewide written examination for the recruitment of police constables